

Right Size. Right Supports. Right for Students.
Synthesis of Engagement Data
April 2026

Executive Summary

Throughout April 2026, the Family and Community Engagement (FACE) team, the Office of School Planning Modernization, and the Office of Strategic Project Management hosted a series of engagement sessions to gather feedback on the school rightsizing process. This effort included six community sessions, a dedicated student advisory session, and meetings with school staff. While the engagement reached a broad cross-section of the district, the resulting data is disproportionately representative of white families (76-80% across most sessions) and families of students identified as Gifted and Talented (TAG). The majority of participants were connected to K-5 school communities, and nearly a third had students enrolled in focus option programs.

When asked to rank the six factors of the PPS Student Assignment Policy, a clear system-wide preference emerged for compact boundaries, "right pathways" (ensuring predictable transitions from elementary to middle and high school), and program balance. However, individual sessions revealed localized deviations from this trend. For instance, families at the Village Table session—representing more marginalized communities—placed a much higher priority on student body demographics and safer routes to school. In contrast, families at Ida B. Wells and Benson prioritized community and enrollment stability, viewing the preservation of established neighborhood hubs as essential to preventing enrollment loss to private institutions.

Participants identified several key factors as essential for a positive school environment, led by a wide variety of learning opportunities and access to specialized services for all student needs. While a warm and welcoming atmosphere was a universal priority, the value placed on diversity varied by session. Participants at Village Table, Kellogg, and Roosevelt explicitly prioritized "learning alongside students from different backgrounds," whereas other sessions focused more on geographic proximity and the ability of neighborhood children to attend the same school. This highlights a tension between the desire for integrated, diverse learning environments and the practical convenience of neighborhood-based schooling.

Synthesis of Slido Data

During the month of April, Portland Public School's Family and Community Engagement (FACE) team, the Office of School Planning Modernization, and the Office of Strategic Project Management worked together to host community engagement sessions regarding the school rightsizing process. A total of six engagement sessions with parents and community members were held, as well as one session with students, and two sessions with elementary school front office staff. During each session, participants were given the opportunity to use a personal electronic device to answer a series of questions using Slido, a digital polling tool. After each engagement session, data were shared with members of the Research, Assessment, and Accountability team for synthesis. This memo synthesizes the feedback received from parents and other community stakeholders across sessions using Slido.

The Slido was available in English, with paper copies available in Chinese, Somali, Spanish, Russian, and Vietnamese by request. As of April 28th, no data in languages other than English was shared with the Research, Assessment, and Accountability team. While the exact number of participants in each session is not available, we are able to report the number of responses for each Slido item. Please note: all demographic questions encouraged participants to select all that apply, and total counts might be higher than the overall number of participants. For that reason, we report counts rather than percentages.

Demographic Analysis

Including the Village Table engagement session and the six public listening sessions, the majority of participants reported being affiliated with K-5 programs. (See Table 1 for more information). A large majority of participants identified as white. (See Table 2 for more information).

Table 1:

Gradeband affiliation of all participants

Gradeband	***Count***
Pre-K	*84*
K-5	*581*
6-9	*150*
9-12	*55*
Not in school yet	*22*
Out of school (K12)	*14*

Table 2:
Count of self-reported race/ethnicity affiliation of participants

Participant Race/Ethnicity	Count
African American/Black	32
American Indian/Alaska Native	18
Asian	29
Hispanic/Latino/Latinx	38
Middle Eastern/North African	9
Pacific Islander	3
White	520
Multiple Racial Identities	61
I prefer not to answer	52

While the majority of participants reported being served by general education services and had not experienced enrollment changes over the course of their time affiliated with PPS, 174 families reported having a student identified as Talented and Gifted, 152 attended focus school options, and 149 reported receiving special education services. A total of 92 participants reported experiencing a boundary change in their school. See Table 3 for additional information.



Table 3:

Responses to the question, "What programs or services have your students participated in?"

Program/Service	Count
None of the these	449
Talented and Gifted	174
Focus option school or program such as the arts or STEM	152
Special education	149
504	112
Boundary change	92
Grade level of their school changed	59
Not sure	35
The program they were attending moved	27
Attended a different school because of storm damage	13
Multilingual learners	12
Opening of a school	8
Attended a different school that was a swing space while their school was modernized	6

Identifying Key Factors in Student Assignment Policy

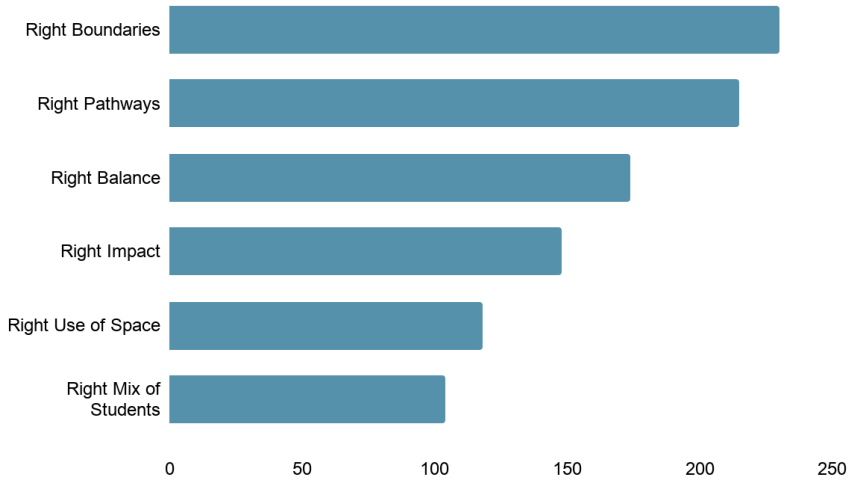
The Portland Public Schools Student Assignment Policy asks stakeholders to consider the six factors, including:

- Right Pathways: A feeder pattern that allows as many students as possible to continue together from one school level to the next
- Right Mix of Students: Student body demographics
- Right Boundaries: Compact boundaries that promote safer routes to schools and a sense of community as well as recognize and address natural and human-made barriers
- Right use of Space: Optimal use of existing facilities
- Right Balance: Program and enrollment stability in the surrounding schools
- Right Impact: Limiting the impact of boundary changes to the smallest number of students possible

When asked to select the three most important factors to consider during program and enrollment balancing, respondents ranked boundaries, pathways, and balance as most important. See Chart 1 for a detailed breakdown of this ranking.

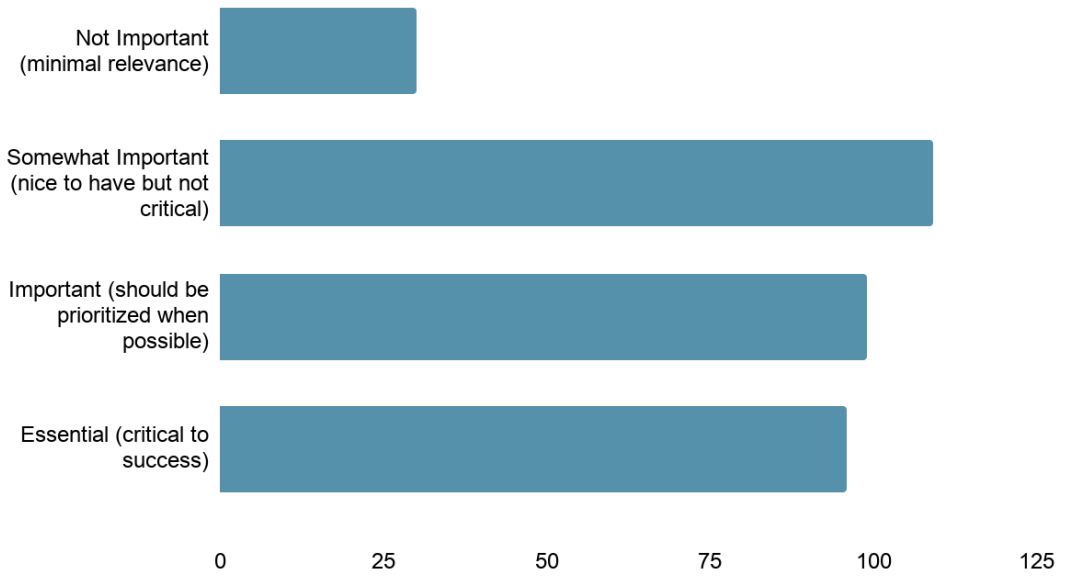
Chart 1:

Responses to the question, "Our Portland Public Schools Student Assignment Policy asks us to consider the following six factors. Please select the three most important factors to consider during program and enrollment balancing across our system."



Additionally, respondents were asked, "How important is it that students and families have access to a variety of learning environments close to where they live?" While the most popular answer was "somewhat important (nice to have but not critical)," many others ranked this as "essential (critical to success)" and "important (should be prioritized when possible)". For that reason, rankings on this item are challenging to interpret. See Chart 2 for detailed responses to this question.

Chart 2:
Responses to the question, "How important is it that students and families have access to a variety of learning environments close to where they live?"



Defining a Positive School Environment

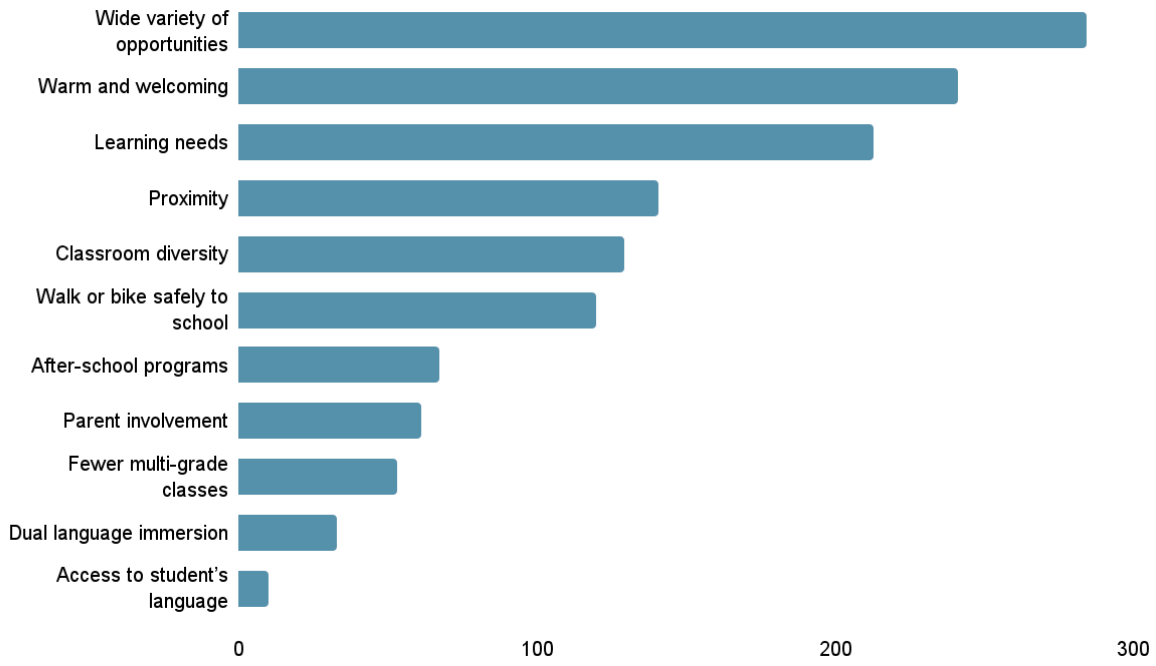
In 2015, a survey was deployed, asking families what they hoped PPS would be like in 2025. The factors that were included as options were:

- Learning alongside children from different backgrounds
- Opportunities for parent involvement
- Access to dual language immersion
- A warm and welcoming school environment
- Wide variety of learning opportunities including access to music, art, library, and physical education
- Access to after-school programs
- Ability of children who live close together to attend the same school
- Access to learning in the student's preferred language
- Ability of children to walk or bike safely to school
- Access to services that meet every student's learning needs (including special education, English as a second language, talented and gifted program)

- Lower likelihood of enrolling in a multi-grade class

In this survey, respondents were asked to select the top four factors that make a positive school environment. They selected a wide variety of learning opportunities, a warm and welcoming school environment, access to services that meet all students' learning needs, and the ability of children who live close together to attend the same school. See Chart 3 for a detailed breakdown of this ranking.

Chart 3:
Responses to the question, "select the top four factors that you think make a positive school environment"



Discussion and Differentiation

Respondent groups in individual listening sessions had significant differences in how they prioritized the six factors of the Student Assignment Policy. While this overall synthesis highlights compact boundaries, right pathways, and program balance as the top three factors system-wide, the individual showed different values.

Geographic proximity was the dominant priority for families in Southwest and Southeast Portland, as well as for many focus-option families, while feeder patterns and compact boundaries were prioritized by respondents who attended sessions at Wells, Benson, and Roosevelt. Additionally, while student body demographics was ranked lower in the overall synthesis (often sitting in the bottom three), it was a top-tier priority for members of the Village Table and respondents at Roosevelt.

When asked about the factors that make a positive school environment, participants across different sessions showed distinct differences in what they prioritized for a positive school environment. While a wide variety of learning opportunities and access to services for all students were universal top concerns, groups differed on the importance of geographic proximity versus diversity and welcoming environments. Members of the Village Table, as well as respondents who participated in sessions at Kellogg, Roosevelt, and Benson ranked the opportunity to learn alongside children from different backgrounds higher than families that attended the Southwest Portland session at Ida B. Wells. However, there was greater turnout at Wells than at other sessions.

In sessions with high concentrations of Talented and Gifted (TAG) families and those that chose focus option programs (e.g., the virtual session and the session at Ida B. Wells), participants expressed different priorities. For example, many families that attended the Ida B. Wells session stated that specialized focus programs or K-8 models keep families opting into enrollment in Portland Public Schools rather than opting for private education. Similarly, families of Gifted and Talented students at the Virtual Session reported moving schools specifically to escape unaddressed learning needs in their assigned neighborhood schools, prioritizing academic rigor over geographic proximity.

Conclusions and Next Steps

After a series of community engagement sessions, the Family and Community Engagement (FACE) team, the Office of School Planning Modernization, and the Office of Strategic Project Management have collected community feedback about priorities for the Student Assignment Policy and information on what makes a positive school environment across Portland Public Schools. This information can be used to inform the priorities in future conversations about school rightsizing.

It is worth considering the limitations of the community voice synthesized across these sessions. White families and families with students labeled as Gifted and Talented (TAG) are disproportionately represented in this dataset, and only English-language responses were collected and synthesized.